

Clauses

A CLAUSE IS THE KEY ELEMENT OF A SENTENCE.

A clause is a group of words that contains a subject and a verb. It can form part of a sentence, or a complete simple sentence. Clauses can be main or subordinate, and they can behave like adjectives or adverbs.

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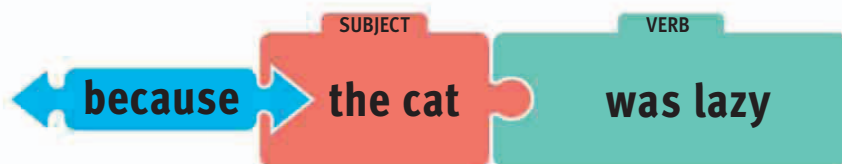
Main clauses

Also known as an independent clause, a main clause includes a subject and a verb and expresses a complete thought. Main clauses are the same as simple sentences, because they have to make sense on their own.



Subordinate clauses

A subordinate clause (also called a dependent clause) contains a subject and a verb, but it does not make sense on its own. It depends on a main clause for its meaning. Subordinate clauses often explain or add more information about where or when things happen, or how they are done. Relative and adverbial clauses are types of subordinate clause.



Identifying main and subordinate clauses

Both main and subordinate clauses have a subject and a verb, but only main clauses make sense on their own. The easiest way to identify a subordinate clause is to look for relative pronouns, such as *which* or *that*, or subordinators, such as *because* or *although*.

The cat went outside, although it was raining.

← This sentence is made up of two clauses.

The cat went outside.

← This is a main clause, because it contains a subject and a verb, and makes complete sense on its own.

although it was raining

← This is a subordinate clause, because it contains a subject (here, a pronoun), a verb, and a subordinator, and it does not make sense on its own.